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By Daniel Desrochers, Oliver Ward, Paroma Soni · Aug 10, 2026, 12:25 PM · View in your browser

President Donald Trump’s message to the American industries hurt by his trade wars is simple: Don’t worry — more countries are going to buy your corn, cars and other goods.

Yet for a president who has described trade deficits as a “politician-made disaster,” exporters are still waiting to see the full benefits of Trump’s year of dealmaking.

U.S. goods exports overall rose by nearly 11 percent in the year leading up to June 2026 compared to the previous 12 months, a POLITICO analysis of the most recent data found. But as administration officials eagerly tout the “quick and impressive results” of Trump’s deals, the gains are uneven and premature.

Take South Korea. While total U.S. exports to the country climbed by 18 percent, products estimated to be covered under a trade deal struck last year went up around 9 percent, falling short of Trump’s promise that South Korea “will be completely OPEN TO TRADE with the United States .”

Trump promoted markets that don’t exist for certain goods and overstated the terms of preliminary verbal agreements. Foreign trading partners have also been slow to pass legislation or lower other trade barriers to implement their end of the deals. So while U.S. businesses have shipped more goods overseas, like trucks and rice to Japan, American producers say it’s too early to tell whether the administration is creating durable new export markets and supply chains that experts say take years to build.

“If you look at a disruption, like a retaliatory tariff, that can knock you out very very quickly. But then to build markets, it just takes so much more time,” said Shawn Arita, a former Agriculture Department economist in both the Trump and Biden administrations. “And I think the way they’ve structured these deals are a lot faster than traditionally what we’ve had. But even there, even if you turbocharge it, it still takes a long time.”

(POLITICO’s analysis estimates export data based on publicly available White House announcements, the Federal Register and data from the Census Bureau. The full lists of products covered under the deals are not available.)

That has left U.S. businesses, particularly farmers, in a challenging position: They absorbed the whiplash and uncertainty of the trade war — which sunk exports to China, a key market, by 18 percent

compared to the prior year — and don't have many new customers to show for it. It also creates political risk for the White House and Republicans, who are already facing deep economic headwinds among voters angry over Trump's trade agenda and its role in driving up prices at home.

"We're very much encouraged by the administration's efforts to expand exports," said Shawna Morris, the executive vice president of trade policy at the U.S. Dairy Export Council, an industry association. "We had a very strong year last year, but of course that was while things were still being negotiated. We're off to a good start this year. Still, we're waiting for the actual policies to be implemented."

Since the U.S. isn't likely to sharply reduce imports anytime soon, Trump's main lever for eliminating the \$102.1 billion trade deficit in goods he cited when he launched his expansive global tariffs is to juice exports.

When touting major trade agreements on Truth Social, Trump celebrated the ways his tariff threats forced countries to open their economies to U.S. goods, whether it was rice exports to Japan or SUVs to Indonesia.

"President Trump's historic trade and tariff agenda has secured almost 20 new trade deals and trillions in investments into American manufacturing," White House spokesperson Kush Desai said. "As these trade deals continue to take effect and these investments continue to materialize, Americans can count on lower goods trade deficits, more jobs, and higher growth."

Those efforts have reassured tariff-skeptic Republicans, many of whom fall back to Trump's promise of expanding market access — particularly for farmers — as a way to assuage constituents wary of the administration's trade agenda.

"I'm not a fan of tariffs, but I am a fan of engagement and the engagement that's been taking place has been productive at getting other countries to reduce their barriers," Rep. Adrian Smith (R-Neb.), the chair of the House Ways and Means trade subcommittee, said in an interview.

Most industries are still hopeful that the deals will help deliver new customers. While the agreements with the European Union, Japan and South Korea garnered splashy headlines, given their size and the longstanding trade relationships with those countries, the U.S. Trade Representative's office quietly secured stronger, signed agreements with 10 other countries, from Argentina to Malaysia.

One of the most significant deals Trump notched last July was with Indonesia, a large — and potentially growing — market in Southeast Asia.

Among the gains the U.S. secured in that deal, which was finalized in February, were provisions allowing the U.S. to sell certain meats and cheeses to Indonesian consumers by their more well-known names — like gouda and asiago — and adjusting Indonesia's licensing regime for U.S. export facilities. The U.S. exported almost 50 percent more cheese to Indonesia in the 12 months leading up to June 2026, compared to the same period the year prior.

Indonesia is one of the countries able to implement its end of the trade deal through executive action alone. Others — like South Korea, Taiwan and the European Union — had to get theirs through their respective legislative branches.

In the case of the EU, a 27-country bloc where the U.S. has a trade surplus of services like financial and tech services, the reduced tariff rate for U.S. goods was only finalized this June, nearly a year after the

deal was officially struck.

Even with the delayed implementation of the tariff exemptions, U.S. goods exports to the European Union, which is collectively the largest U.S. trading partner, rose by 14 percent, significantly lowering the goods deficit with the region in recent months. That shift was driven by the bloc's purchases of U.S. crude oil and liquified natural gas, which increased following the joint U.S.-Israel war with Iran and subsequent disruptions to crude supply.

Exports of crude to Japan and South Korea have seen similar surges, while U.S. exports of crude overall have increased by a further 4 percent since March.

In other cases, the president pushed goods that might not necessarily attract significant demand.

The steel industry's largest export markets are Mexico and Canada — and the trade agreements did little to drive up exports elsewhere. That's largely because the steel industry is struggling to compete with cheap steel from places like China and India, where it is subsidized by their governments, making it hard to find significant export markets, according to Kevin Dempsey at the American Iron and Steel Institute, a trade association representing U.S. steel producers.

The administration also pushed trading partners like the European Union, Argentina, Guatemala and El Salvador to accept U.S. motor vehicle safety standards, which Cox Automotive executive analyst Erin Keating said may not actually increase demand for U.S. trucks and SUVs.

"A vehicle still has to fit local market preferences, and in many of these countries the biggest constraints have historically been product mix, vehicle size, fuel costs, taxes and consumer preferences, rather than safety certification alone," Keating said. "In other words, making it easier to sell a vehicle doesn't necessarily make consumers more likely to buy it."

A report compiled by the Autos Drive America and the American International Automobile Dealers Association, two groups that represent international auto companies, found that exports of U.S.-made automobiles were down 5.5 percent — a loss of about \$1 billion in vehicle exports year over year.

But in some cases, the result of the trade deals were straightforward. Japan quickly followed through with its promise to purchase 75 percent more rice than it did in the 2024-25 marketing year. The U.S. exported nearly \$400 million worth of rice to Japan in the last 12 months, compared with around \$327 billion the year prior.

"We are very excited about that," said Peter Bachmann, president and CEO at the USA Rice Federation, which represents U.S. rice farmers, millers and vendors. And Bachmann is optimistic the increased purchases will persist.

Other industries are waiting for similar trade gains to materialize. The United Kingdom has stood up a new quota to allow 13,000 metric tons of U.S. beef to enter tariff-free. The first shipments under that quota hit U.K. shelves in March, but U.S. exporters have not seen an early surge in sales.

Beef exports must still meet U.K. standards, including curbs on hormone treatments and certain slaughter methods, which are not widely met in the U.S.

Lingering nontariff barriers are also likely to undermine the utility of the European Union's duty-free quotas for U.S. pork and bison that took effect July 1, according to Erin Borrer, vice president for economic analysis at the U.S. Meat Export Federation.

“It will take some time for any new U.S. suppliers to enter the picture,” Borrer said in an email, “but the duty-free quota is at least a start toward meaningful market access.”

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